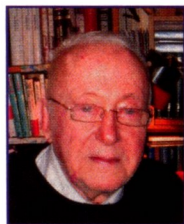


guest column

By Roy Aleksandrovich Medvedev

THE NEW CZAR

Despite giving up the presidency, Putin controls all the levers of power and has emerged as the de facto national leader. There is really only one Czar in Russia today—Putin.



When Vladimir Putin was recently asked if he could list his failures as a President, he paused, thought and replied: "I do not remember any major failure." I agree with him because, in these eight years, Putin dealt with every issue methodically. After the Soviet Union disintegrated, the Russian Federation headed by Boris

Yeltsin deteriorated further. Contact with the regions and the federation was almost non-existent. There was a total absence of what is called vertical power in the country. Yeltsin was not even in control of Moscow because the Moscow mayor could do anything. The situation in the Caucasian regions and the central parts of Russia was no different—they could do what they wanted to do. All major branches of economy—metallurgy and machine building—were ruined. Everything had disintegrated. There was no economic management. We were told that we had democracy but I personally rated it as anarchy.

Therefore when Putin came to power his first and foremost task was to unite Russia as a nation state. He re-established the army as it had taken a beating in the civil war in Chechnya. He also revived the intelligence agencies apart from all the major branches of the economy. So in the first four years, his task was to revive the Russian state and restore vertical power. His second term saw him focus on the economic revival of the country. He promised to double the GDP and improve the living standards of people. On the political front he wanted to establish a multi-party political system and to restore Russia's place in the world so that its national interests were taken seriously. By and large Putin succeeded in achieving these targets.

Putin is a transformed person from what I saw when he was the head of intelligence agency FSB. Power hasn't corrupted or destroyed him as it did Yeltsin. Yeltsin gave the impression of being a tough and strong politician. But in 1999 when he gave up his presidency to Putin, Yeltsin couldn't even stand on his legs and didn't understand what was going on around him. In the early days, Putin was shabbily dressed and shy of the media. Now he holds marathon press conferences. Initially he didn't know what business was all about and was not prepared to handle that kind of responsibility. But over the years he has transformed himself into a well-informed

PUTIN WANTS TO BE ANOTHER PETER THE Great but is not there yet. He requires another 10 years to complete the work he has begun. If he succeeds he will be regarded as the father of a new modern Russia.

and knowledgeable leader. He has become competent and his intellect and will power stand out. He has surpassed all those who came along with him to power and is intellectually far ahead of them. Putin's style of functioning is quiet, even secretive. He never allows anyone to know how he takes his decisions and most often surprises everyone with his conclusions. He doesn't scream at people or threaten them but gives them directions and religiously checks back whether his instructions are carried out. He is a tough leader.

Putin continues to enjoy colossal popularity because of his outstanding performance. When Yeltsin left, there were just 10,000 people whose personal worth was over \$1 million each and there were only eight billionaires in the country. Today the number of millionaires has increased to five lakh and there are 101 billionaires. The country is just behind the US in the number of billionaires, much ahead of India, though Indians are competing with us. In the past two years in the taking-over spree of metallurgical plants in Europe, the competition was between Lakshmi Mittal—an Indian and Alexei Mordashov—a Russian. In the end Mittal won the battle for Arcelor. But re-